Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Frank Capp

Drummer Frank Capp is one of the busiest percussionists on the West Coast. Born in Worcester, Massachusetts in 1931, he attended Boston University and got his first break in the music business by replacing Shelly Manne in Stan Kenton's orchestra in 1951. His subsequent big band work included gigs with Billy May and Neal Hefti. In the late 50s he found a home at the West Coast Warner Brothers studio, recording for numerous T.V. and film scores and playing with the popular Andre Previn Trio. He became part of the vital West Coast jazz scene, performing with Marty Paich, Art Pepper and Stan Getz. Frank has played behind some of the great singers, including Ella Fitzgerald, Ernestine Anderson and Joe Williams. In 1975 he founded the Capp-Pierce Juggernaut with Pianist Nat Pierce.

Frank was interviewed in Los Angeles on September 3, 1995 by Monk Rowe. Mary Kopcza also participated briefly in the interview.

MR: Good afternoon. We're filming here today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a great pleasure to be here with Frank Capp, who seems to be one of the busiest drummers on the West Coast from the description he just gave us of his upcoming weekend with the L.A. Classic Jazz Fest. And thanks, Frank, for coming in and squeezing in some time with us.

FC: Well it's a pleasure, Monk, thanks for inviting me.

MR: Did this kind of popularity kind of come overnight for you?

FC: Well actually, I've kind of been, over the last many years I've been kind of hidden as it were, by studio work. But back in 1976 I decided that I had enough of that, you know I mean not that I still don't do an occasional studio call, but that was my main focus after I got off the road with the bands, the many bands I played with and acts and all of that, I settled in at the studios. And I made a good living doing that. And never gave up, ever gave up playing jazz. But unfortunately studio musicians don't get any exposure into the jazz public. And so it wasn't until '76 when I started Juggernaut with Nat Pierce, that I kind of threw the towel in on the studio stuff. And so it didn't happen overnight. You know I've been around a long time as my age will attest.

MR: You are East Coast — moved to the West Coast.

FC: Right. I was born in Worcester, Massachusetts and I joined Stan Kenton when I was nineteen.

MR: Wow.

FC: That was my first professional job.

MR: That's a kind of a high pressure job for a first one, too.

FC: It really was. And I was still wet behind the ears as it were, and, but Stan was good. He nurtured me and helped me along and after that band I did several other road bands — Neal Hefti's band and Billy May, Charlie Barnet; and I worked with a lot of singers — Peggy Lee, Ella Fitz, I worked with Dorothy Dandridge for a while and then she had a sad ending, committed suicide. But I also worked with Betty Hutton. I did a lot of those kind of things. The only, and we were just mentioning about Andre Previn. I worked with Andre for almost eight years. I must have made about 25 albums with him. It was right after the "My Fair Lady" album which made quite a bit of noise as it were, and on the charts etc., back then. And that "My Fair Lady" album was done with Shelly Manne and Leroy Vinnegar. And Shelly was so busy, incredibly busy, he couldn't travel with Andre, so Andre hired me and Red Mitchell and Red and I and Andre were the Andre Previn Trio for over eight years. We traveled, made albums with everybody from Mahalia Jackson to Doris Day to vocalists, and we had J.J. Johnson, we did an album with a whole bunch of singers, you know a choir. We did a lot of things. Andre was very prolific in that day. He still is for that matter. But he used to write, Andre used to write movies, a lot of movie scores. And he also got tired of the Hollywood scene and aspired to be a classical conductor, a la Leonard Bernstein. And he pursued that so he dropped the trio and dropped jazz altogether, until he made it as a classical conductor.

MR: Not too many people have gone that route.

FC: No.

MR: From jazz into classical.

FC: No. But he's back doing jazz again, playing you know, and recording an occasional album.

MR: You must have had some, from the work you're describing, did you have some actual percussion training when you were young or has it kind of been —

FC: You know oddly enough, I can still hear my mother reprimanding me for not practicing. Can't hear him practice. And I did have some training. I went to Boston University and I was in Boston University when Stan called me to join the band. So I left I think in my junior year. I never got my degree. But I had enough classical training as a percussionist to get me through most of what I would need later in the studios. Because as a nineteen year old, my aspirations were to be a big band jazz drummer. And I've never lost that aspiration. I'm still trying to be a big band jazz drummer.

MR: That must be a great feeling — to drive a big band — I would think.

FC: Yeah. I enjoy it very much. I love working with my band, but I love working with a lot of other bands, as you just mentioned, this weekend is pretty busy with me. And tomorrow I'm going to be down at the Marriott where there's another jazz party going on with Terry Gibbs Dream Band. And then tonight I'm going up to Santa Barbara to do a

concert with Supersax. Now Med Flory has added a brass section to Supersax, and four voices. So it's now the L.A. Voices he calls it. Sue Raney is the lead singer and the brass section, so it's kind of, what do you call it, Supersax with voices? Or, I don't know, it doesn't matter what it's called, it's still big band and it's fun to do. I like all kinds of playing. I enjoy doing what we're doing here at this and I'm playing, I just finished, as I said, last night I went down and did a set with Terry Gibbs and Buddy DeFranco down at the other hotel. And that's about as beboppish as you can get. And I just finished, I got off the stage downstairs doing an out-and-out Dixieland set you know. And I love it. I love it all.

MR: You've got to change hats from one day to the next.

FC: Right, sure. I mean a lot of, there was a day when a lot of hippy musicians thought that there was no validity in Dixieland or the traditional swing. But that's not true. There's great music everywhere.

MR: Yeah. It's really gratifying to be here and see, first of all, the old veterans. But then there's some younger guys coming up too, who seem to have a pretty good handle on the classic swing.

FC: Well what's happened, thanks to our education system, they have allowed, or have created jazz programs. When I was in school, you couldn't even use the word jazz. That was a no-no. There was no jazz education at all. In my high school, all I got was a music appreciation class and we listened to classics. Nothing. Jazz was an illegitimate music as far as that era of thinking was concerned. But certainly we know better than that now and certainly because of the great educational program, there is all kinds of young kids coming up. And you say, jeez, where'd they learn how to do that? Well they learned how to do it in school. All they need is a little experience and to sand off some of the rough edges and they'll be great. They'll be equally as good as any of us who so-called grew up with that music you know.

MR: Yeah. I think Herb Ellis said some of them just need to figure out what not to play now.

FC: That's right. Exactly, exactly. But music is, all music is great, except one.

MR: Okay, what kind of music?

FC: Well I'm going to tell you this story about Buddy Rich. You know everyone in the world knows Buddy. And unfortunately he had a brain tumor and he was being prepared to go into surgery. And he was probably sedated, and he was on the gurney and the nurse was about to give him a shot or something, whatever, before going into surgery. And she said, "Mr. Rich, are you allergic to anything?" And he kind of dazed open his eyes and said, "Yeah. Country-Western music." Now that ought to give you an idea of that man's wit. And I kind of feel the same way actually.

MR: That's not a hat you're going to put on someday soon.

FC: No, absolutely not.

MR: All right. Can you describe to us what it's like to try to run a big band? Because I know you and Nat —

FC: Well we've persevered a lot more. Even Terry. You know Terry Gibbs had a great band in the 50s, that dream band. It wasn't called a dream band then, but he worked a couple of nights a week at a club called The Summit and another one called The Sundown where he recorded all, if you're not familiar with his albums, called The Dream Band, and they were recorded by an engineer who just happened to, for a hobby, recorded the band. And he made all of these tapes that are now on Fantasy. Look at me I'm pushing Fantasy instead of my own company which is Concord.

MR: Go for it.

FC: But anyway, that band, at that time, they stayed together because there weren't a lot of bands. Now what's happening in L.A., there are a plethora of bands. I mean if you've got any kind of music rehearsal band or anything at all, you are now a big band leader. It's not easy keeping a band cohesive unless you're working a lot.

MR: Yeah, you can't hold on to the personnel so much.

FC: Yeah. And thanks be, for whatever reason, Juggernaut has always worked a lot for not being a traveling band, you know for not being a road band like the Basie band or Mercer Ellington, and all of the other ghost bands you know. But it's not an easy job but we manage to keep most of the same musicians. We had Marshall Royal in our band right up until he died a few months ago, right from the very first album, and a lot of guys that were with us at the very first album which was done in 1976 I think was Bill Green is still with us, a couple of trombone players, Buster Cooper was until he just moved to Florida. So we have kept a pretty consistent personnel in our orchestra. But it's not easy because you know you can't —

MR: Everybody's got to make a living.

FC: Yeah. Everybody's got to make a living. You can't, unfortunately, this country's got its values all screwed up, all screwed up. Musicians who spend and devote their life to become really facile on their instruments and help create pleasure for people, make nothing. And some athletic dummy, you know, goes out and bangs his head against somebody else's helmet and they make millions and millions. But that's another story.

MR: That sure is. Shortly after you got the band together, didn't you do an album with Joe Williams?

FC: Yes we did. That was our second album. Our first album was just called Juggernaut. And the reason it was called Juggernaut — now that you've asked — the reason it was called Juggernaut is because Nat and I put the band together for a one-night situation to help a guy who was running big bands at a club called King Arthur's in the San Fernando

Valley. And he had hired Neal Hefti's band and Neal disbanded before the engagement came up. And I was contracting for Neal, so the club owner asked me to put a big band together. I did. I got Nat, we went out, and we called it "A Tribute to Count Basie." And we worked that first night, and that was all it was going to be. And the crowd liked it so much, and the club owner liked it so much, he said, "You've got to come back next week." Well we did and we came back subsequent weeks for a couple of months, and Leonard Feather, the jazz critic for the *L.A. Times* at that point, came out to review the band. And the next day in his article it said, "A juggernaut on Basie Street." That was the title of the review. So at that particular time, everybody had a name to the band. Buddy Rich had the Big Band Machine, and Louie Bellson had Big Band Explosion, and everybody, they were putting a tag on all of it. So I said, "Nat, let's use the name 'Juggernaut.'" So we subsequently recorded that first album, and Carl Jefferson from Concord said, "Let's call the album 'Juggernaut.'" I kind of wish that we never used the word quite frankly, because people don't know how to spell it. They are forever asking me what is a Juggernaut, and a lot of people call it "Juggernauts" and it's not a plural. But anyway.

MR: What was it like working with Joe on that album?

FC: Joe Williams is a sweetheart, and he's a great singer, and he is so laid back. I mean he'll come into a gig situation, of course he's got to feel pretty comfortable with who's on the stand behind him. But he'll walk in and he won't have to rehearse anything you know. He'll bring his charts maybe, maybe he won't bring his charts, maybe we'll just fake stuff. He's so easy to work with. And that album that we did, "Live at the Century Plaza," we had recorded maybe three or four tunes other than what's on the album. And one tune, which we didn't plan to record, which was "Joe's Blues," it's an eleven minute thing. We were just, because we did it live and we were now catering to the audience rather than the microphones, so Joe just turned around and said to Nat, "B flat." Nat put it down. And we played. And if you've heard the album, it's eleven minutes of joy. It's just wonderful. And it was the first and last time we've ever played that that way. And we liked it so much that we threw the other tunes that we planned to use on the album out, and just kept that one and "What the World Needs Now."

MR: That's interesting because that's one of the parts about jazz I think that some people find so fascinating. Like how did you do that — he just said "B flat" and you played for eleven minutes you know. And that's the beauty of the music in some respects.

FC: Well there's an empathy that exists between most all professional musicians — most all — sometimes not. But given a situation like this certainly everybody kind of melted in the wind and became cohesive.

MR: Give us a little idea of what a typical studio date would be like. Because this isn't something that like for instance students really have a handle on what it requires.

FC: Well let me example something like a motion picture call — a motion picture session. What would happen is you'd be given a call by a contractor to be at Warner Brothers Studio or Universal or MGM when it was MGM, whatever, and you'd go to the studio at 9 o'clock in the morning, and there would be 60, 70 musicians, depending. It could be a small group too, but a lot of pictures used at that time, large orchestras. And you walk in, and the librarian hands out the music. You open it to page one or whatever, and play. Here it is: one-two-three play. And you have to play that music like you wrote it, or like you've been playing it for — I mean rarely, rarely in those days did you get a chance to play it more than twice. Maybe three times. You'd run it down for notes, to make sure there was no copying errors. And then you begin recording. And if it was a tight budget picture, which is the case now, you don't get a second chance. I mean you're on the edge of your seat at all times.

MR: I guess.

FC: But that, I'll tell you something. What happens with that is almost similar to the example you just gave when you point to B flat and an empathy exists with an orchestra like that too, and you just, it just comes together. You know you're all professionals, you're professional musicians and that's what you're expected to do.

MR: Yeah. Play it right the first time.

FC: Yeah. That's right.

MR: What about some of the, you've worked with some great soloists too — Art Pepper, and Stan Getz.

FC: Art Pepper, Stan Getz, I worked with Marty Paich. In fact, did you know Marty Paich, the pianist?

MR: I know of him. I never met him.

FC: He was a great arranger. Great arranger and great piano player too. And I did a lot of work with him. Do you know I can't remember, I mean there's so many. I mean you name 'em, I probably worked with them. Benny Carter, Ray Brown. I did twelve years on *The Red Skelton Show* when, fellows who remember variety television, I did that with David Rose.

MR: Was that live?

FC: Yeah, that was a live show.

MR: Did you ever have any interesting things happen in those kind of situations?

FC: Not, nothing, you know there was always little glitches that you say oops, I wish I could do that again but you don't get a chance to do it again. But nothing really momentous. Except that Martha Raye, if you know who she was, she was a singer, she used to come

on the show and the dress rehearsals, the dress rehearsals — CBS. Every office in CBS was closed during the dress rehearsals because they all funneled down into Studio 33 where we were rehearsing because between Red and Martha it was the most risqué, dirty show.

MR: It wasn't about to make it on the air that way, huh?

FC: Oh, no it was never— I often wondered, and I think someone might have taped those dress rehearsals. And if they do they're a gold mine if they ever get — because in today's world, what she said and what he said, I mean at that time it was very funny and considered very dirty. But if you watch any of the cable comedy shows now, God, that sense of humor is just repulsive some of it. Anyway.

MR: Well we've had a great time—

FC: We didn't talk about Count Basie.

MK: You have seven and a half minutes left.

MR: Oh, I'm sorry. I thought my watch was slow. We've had some great conversations with people trying to figure out what was it that made the Basie band swing like it did.

FC: Well I mean there could be a lot of theories. But first of all I think it comes from the leader. I mean Count Basie had a great, great sense of time. He was a swinging piano player. He could hit two notes and you could feel the swing. I think maybe that's where it stems. Secondly, he had great arrangements, or maybe that's thirdly. Maybe secondly is the men. Because he had great swinging players. He had the cream of the crop back in the 40s. I mean you couldn't, every band in the country at that time idolized the band for its swingingness — its looseness and — Jo Jones, old Papa Jo Jones was one of the main contributors to that. And Sweets Edison was on that band. And Snooky Young. And I did a set with Sweets last night and my 1:30 set is with Snooky.

MR: Well we spoke with them yesterday and it was marvelous.

FC: Oh you talked with them? That must have been great. I mean Sweets has got some of the funniest expressions — I doubt whether he used them all — but you know like some of those Southern colloquialisms you call them. Like, "He's tighter than a chicken's instep." You know that kind of thing. Or, "He's so cheap he's got enough money to air condition a cotton field.

MR: One of the guys said, "If he looked any sharper I'd be bleeding."

FC: He's got a million of those, and some that I wouldn't want to talk about here. But Sweets is great. And it was so much fun playing with him. He still has that great sense of time and swing. He doesn't have to play a lot of notes. And tempo doesn't bother him, anything. The only thing I noticed last night, which I haven't worked with Sweets now for a couple of years. I haven't been on the same stand with him. But I noticed he has to sit down now when he plays — he sits on a chair. I did a tour with Sweets and Buck

Clayton in Europe. It was called "The Count's Men" — it was all the old Basie alumni. And Freddie Green was there and Nat played Count's part, I played the drums and Jo Jones, who was alive at the time, followed us around France. We did a month in France. And at that time he was ailing pretty badly.

MR: He was living there?

FC: Yeah. He was living in France. So I got him up on the drums at one concert in Limoges. And he was walking with a cane. And he sat down at the drums and he picked his sticks up, and Eddie Jones was the bass player. He looked down and said, "It's a ballad — the next tune is a ballad." And Papa Jo looked over him in his cantankerous way as he always was and said, "You don't tell me I tell you." And so he proceeded to play. They played the ballad and then they played a brighter tune like "Jumpin' at the Woodside" or something. And I really felt so sad because Papa Jo just lost it, you know he lost the dexterity. He just couldn't keep up the tempo. But right to the end —

MR: Well he made his contribution.

FC: Oh, yeah, he sure did. Mr. Hi Hat, you know. He's the one who invented that style of playing. But I'm glad you — this is going to be a great contribution to your school — whatever you're going to do with this taping.

MR: Yeah, well we feel that this music is such a big part of this country.

FC: It is, it is. Thank God — I could kiss you for saying that. I mean it's America's heritage, you know?

MR: That's right. Home grown.

FC: Right. You know all the other art forms have come from Europe. That's why I say about our country — we've got a lot of catching up to do in that area.

MR: Well some people have mentioned that when they've gone to Europe and the Europeans say to them, you know, your country is very young. And in a way I think some of our problems stem from that, is that we have a ways to go.

FC: You know you can put the greatest marquee together of the greatest jazz stars in this country. And maybe, maybe you'll get a thousand people. Maybe. Not for sure. You go to Japan, you go to Europe, with that same card, and you'll have fifty thousand people. Or twenty thousand people. Vastly more than here. People aren't interested in jazz here, except the few that understand and appreciate it and realize its meaning. And it's not that difficult to understand. People say they don't understand it. What's there to understand? You feel the beat and you feel the rhythm, and well— I don't want to pontificate here, get on my soapbox when I talk about it. But it's really unfortunate that — someone told me that this was before the Iron Curtain came down and all that, that in Russia — I've never been to Russia, but Benny Goodman went to Russia. And someone said that at that time if you were a musician or an artist, you were revered over there. Whether it be jazz music

or classic music. The musicians made more than the doctors or engineers did. That's how they appreciated it. But maybe not so now I don't know. Anyway.

MR: Well thanks so much for you time.

FC: Monk, it was a pleasure sitting here talking with you. I like to talk about these kind of things. And I'm not a fountain of knowledge but I do have my own beliefs.

MR: You have your opinions and we're glad to hear them today. So for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive I want to thank Frank Capp for sharing all that wisdom with us. And I hope you get through your next three or four days where you seem to be playing constantly.

FC: Yes, I will. Because music keeps you young and alive.

MR: All right.

FC: Okay, thank you Monk.